This isn't merely a cultural issue, it is an economic handicap.

The Nordic nations—Denmark, Norway, Sweden and Finland—have achieved their remarkable prosperity partly through the full integration of women in economic and political life. When Norway mandated 40 per cent female representation on corporate boards in 2003, sceptics predicted economic havoc. Instead, Norwegian firms saw improved governance and financial performance, a pattern evident across economies that embraced gender equality.

India's female labour force participation rate hovers at around 41 per cent, far below that of China (60 per cent) and the United States (58 per cent). A 2018 McKinsey & Company study estimates that India's GDP could potentially increase by 27 per cent if India can increase its female workforce participation to the same level as men.

Public safety is more than a law enforcement issue; it is a determinant of economic activity. Tourists, businesses and investors are drawn to environments where they feel secure. Countries with low crime rates—such as Singapore and Switzerland—consistently rank among the most prosperous and remain popular destinations for global tourists. The survey shows 86 per cent respondents feel safe on public transport, but significant gender disparities lurk below the surface. In urban India, women's restricted mobility due to safety concerns represents an enormous economic opportunity cost.

Consider Japan, where women can safely navigate public spaces at any hour. This safety infrastructure translates directly into economic participation—women can work late shifts, attend evening classes, or participate in networking events without security concerns limiting their choices. The economic dividend of safety is so substantial that the McKinsey Global Institute estimates that advancing women's equality in the Asia Pacific could add $4.5 trillion to the region's annual GDP by 2025, a 12 per cent increase over the business-as-usual trajectory.

Another telling statistic: 84 per cent respondents claim they would report a violent crime, yet in cities like Delhi, FIR registration remains abysmally low (only 7.2 per cent of theft victims formally report crimes). This discrepancy signals a lack of trust in the system, which, if unaddressed, discourages civic engagement.

Perhaps most revealing are the findings on diversity and discrimination.

THE REAL CHALLENGE IS NOT TEACHING ETHICS IN THE ABSTRACT BUT ENSURING ACCOUNTABILITY, COMPELLING INDIVIDUALS TO PRACTICE WHAT THEY PROFESS TO BELIEVE

The survey reveals progress alongside persistent challenges. If 70 per cent of the respondents are comfortable with religious diversity in their neighbourhoods, 60 per cent oppose religious discrimination in employment opportunities. These are encouraging movements in the desired direction. Cities like London, Dubai and Toronto—where diverse communities coexist—consistently rank among the world's most innovative and economically vibrant hubs, as evidenced by the global "Innovation Cities Index". The openness of these cities to different perspectives has created a fertile environment for entrepreneurship and creativity.

Most striking is the stark resistance to interfaith and inter-caste marriages—61 per cent of the respondents oppose the former, and 56 per cent the latter. This is not just personal prejudice, it speaks of deep-seated social divisions that have economic implications.

As economists increasingly recognise the limits of conventional development models, this survey points toward a more holistic understanding. A nation's development is not dictated solely by policy prescriptions or economic blueprints. It is shaped on the streets, in classrooms, in public transport queues, and in homes where gender roles are negotiated.

Or maybe in a stadium. Like in Copenhagen, in the summer of 2021. During a UEFA Euro football match between host Denmark and Finland, Denmark's star midfielder Christian Eriksen collapsed following a cardiac arrest. But the crowd didn't descend into panic or chaos. Instead, fans formed a human shield to protect his privacy while medical teams worked. Outside the stadium, Danes quietly gathered, concern etched on their faces rather than spectacle-seeking. It was a moment that demonstrated the deep civic consciousness ingrained in Danish society—a society consistently ranked among the world's "happiest" and most economically successful.

This incident, seemingly unrelated to economic indicators or development metrics, reveals something profound about the invisible architecture of prosperous nations. It reflects a society where trust, responsibility and equality are no abstract notions but lived practices that permeate economic life. As India navigates its development journey, the India Today GDB survey could serve as a reminder that progress is not merely dictated by policy from the top but is a ground-up transformation driven by the everyday choices of millions. ■

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